STATE & VARNA SOCIETY IN THE AGE OF THE BUDDHA

PERIOD HORIZON AND SOURCE → FROM JANA TO TERRITORIAL → SECOND URBANISATION AS A → AGRARIAN BASE, IRON AND → STATE INSTITUTIONS AND DIFFERENTIATED → VARNA NORM AND SOCIAL

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA ● APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • active generation g2 • explicit approval of this exact generation is required • all prior artifacts unchanged

00

STAGE 00

PERIOD HORIZON AND SOURCE METHOD

PERIOD HORIZON AND SOURCE METHOD | LATER VEDIC BACKGROUND | C. 600-400 BCE CORE | C. 600-200 BCE WIDER HORIZON AGRARIAN AND VARNA CHANGE | NIKAYAS/VINAYA + JAINA TEXTS + DHARMASUTRAS/PANINI + ARCHAEOLOGY | DO NOT MAKE UNLIKE SOURCES EXACTLY CONTEMPORARY. | NAMED SOURCE/SITE | WHAT IT PROVES

LATER VEDIC BACKGROUND → c.

600-400 BCE CORE → c.

600-200 BCE WIDER HORIZON agrarian and varna change Buddha-age polities textual redaction and urban growth

SOURCES: Nikayas/Vinaya + Jaina texts + Dharmasutras/Panini + archaeology

Do not make unlike sources exactly contemporary.

CHRONOLOGY / PHASE

- LATER VEDIC BACKGROUND → c.
- 600-400 BCE CORE → c.

MATERIAL / INSTITUTION

- 600-200 BCE WIDER HORIZON agrarian and varna change Buddha-age polities textual redaction and urban growth
- SOURCES: Nikayas/Vinaya + Jaina texts + Dharmasutras/Panini + archaeology

IMPACT / LIMIT

- Do not make unlike sources exactly contemporary.
- METHOD: claim → named source/site → what it proves → transmission limit.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: METHOD: claim → named source/site → what it proves → transmission limit.

01

STAGE 01

FROM JANA TO TERRITORIAL STATE

FROM JANA TO TERRITORIAL STATE | KIN COMMUNITY | SETTLED TERRITORY | LARGER COMPETING MAHAJANAPADAS | MONARCHIES AND GANA-SANGHAS | REVENUE + ARMY + FORTIFIED CENTRES + OFFICIALS + | POLITICAL AUTHORITY BECAME MORE TERRITORIAL AND EXTRACTIVE. | CHANGE WAS REGIONALLY UNEVEN AND DID NOT ERASE CLAN

KIN COMMUNITY / JANA

settled territory / JANAPADA

larger competing MAHAJANAPADAS

monarchies and gana-sanghas

MECHANISMS: revenue + army + fortified centres + officials + diplomacy

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- KIN COMMUNITY / JANA
- settled territory / JANAPADA
- larger competing MAHAJANAPADAS

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- monarchies and gana-sanghas
- MECHANISMS: revenue + army + fortified centres + officials + diplomacy
- RESULT: political authority became more territorial and extractive.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- LIMIT: change was regionally uneven and did not erase clan structures.
- TRAP: gana-sangha was restricted oligarchy, not modern democracy.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — RESULT: political authority became more territorial and extractive.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP: gana-sangha was restricted oligarchy, not modern democracy.

02

STAGE 02

SECOND URBANISATION AS A SYSTEM

SECOND URBANISATION AS A SYSTEM | AGRARIAN SURPLUS | SPECIALISED CRAFTS | TOWNS STATE DEMAND <- TAXES, ARMIES, OFFICIALS <- MERCHANTS | URBANISATION WAS A NETWORK OF PRODUCTION, POWER AND CIRCULATION | NBPW IS AN ASSOCIATED MATERIAL HORIZON, NOT THE SINGLE

AGRARIAN SURPLUS → SPECIALISED CRAFTS → EXCHANGE → TOWNS state demand <- taxes

armies, officials <- merchants and householders roads + rivers + coin use

Urbanisation was a network of production, power and circulation.

NBPW is an associated material horizon, not the single cause of towns.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- AGRARIAN SURPLUS → SPECIALISED CRAFTS → EXCHANGE → TOWNS state demand <- taxes,
- armies, officials <- merchants and householders roads + rivers + coin use

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Urbanisation was a network of production, power and circulation.
- NBPW is an associated material horizon, not the single cause of towns.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- AGRARIAN SURPLUS → SPECIALISED CRAFTS → EXCHANGE → TOWNS state demand <- taxes,
- armies, officials <- merchants and householders roads + rivers + coin use

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: NBPW is an associated material horizon, not the single cause of towns.

03

STAGE 03

AGRARIAN BASE, IRON AND REVENUE

AGRARIAN BASE, IRON AND REVENUE | FOREST CLEARANCE + PLOUGH AGRICULTURE + LABOUR LARGER AND | TERRITORIAL COMPETITION | IRON ENABLED TOOLS AND WEAPONS BUT DID NOT MECHANICALLY

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- FOREST CLEARANCE + PLOUGH AGRICULTURE + LABOUR larger and more regular surplus shares, tribute,
- labour dues and market-related extraction treasury → officials → army → territorial competition

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- CAUTION: iron enabled tools and weapons but did not mechanically create states.
- FOREST CLEARANCE + PLOUGH AGRICULTURE + LABOUR larger and more regular surplus shares, tribute,

DEBATE / LEGACY

- labour dues and market-related extraction treasury → officials → army → territorial competition
- CAUTION: iron enabled tools and weapons but did not mechanically create states.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CAUTION: iron enabled tools and weapons but did not mechanically create states.

04

STAGE 04

STATE INSTITUTIONS AND DIFFERENTIATED OFFICES

STATE INSTITUTIONS AND DIFFERENTIATED OFFICES | RULING LINEAGE MINISTERS AND MAHAMATTAS | REVENUE AND JUDICIAL FUNCTIONS ARMY AND COMMANDERS | COERCION AND DEFENCE VILLAGE HEADS | LOCAL MEDIATION AND COLLECTION ENVOYS AND ALLIANCES | INTERSTATE COMPETITION | OFFICE TERMS SHOW FUNCTIONAL DIFFERENTIATION, NOT A UNIFORM MAURYAN | RESOURCES + INFORMATION + COMPLIANCE, NOT TITLES ALONE.

RAJAN / RULING LINEAGE ministers and mahamattas → revenue and judicial functions army and commanders

coercion and defence village heads → local mediation and collection envoys and alliances → interstate

Office terms show functional differentiation, not a uniform Mauryan bureaucracy.

Capacity + resources + information + compliance, not titles alone.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- RAJAN / RULING LINEAGE ministers and mahamattas → revenue and judicial functions army and commanders →
- coercion and defence village heads → local mediation and collection envoys and alliances → interstate competition

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Office terms show functional differentiation, not a uniform Mauryan bureaucracy.
- Capacity + resources + information + compliance, not titles alone.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- RAJAN / RULING LINEAGE ministers and mahamattas → revenue and judicial functions army and commanders →
- coercion and defence village heads → local mediation and collection envoys and alliances → interstate competition

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Capacity + resources + information + compliance, not titles alone.

05

STAGE 05

VARNA NORM AND SOCIAL PRACTICE

VARNA NORM AND SOCIAL PRACTICE | BRAHMANICAL NORM LIVED SOCIAL FIELD FOURFOLD RANKED VARNA OCCUPATIONS | VARNA ORGANISED CLAIMS TO HIERARCHY; IT DID NOT FULLY | NEITHER TIMELESS RIGIDITY NOR UNRESTRICTED MOBILITY IS EVIDENCE-SAFE.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY	EVIDENCE / MECHANISM	DEBATE / LEGACY
BRAHMANICAL NORM LIVED SOCIAL FIELD fourfold ranked varna occupations, jatis, clans and regions duty and ritual status wealth, power, mobility and exclusion prescriptive texts Buddhist/Jaina texts + archaeology	Varna organised claims to hierarchy; it did not fully describe every social relation. Neither timeless rigidity nor unrestricted mobility is evidence-safe.	BRAHMANICAL NORM LIVED SOCIAL FIELD fourfold ranked varna occupations, jatis, clans and regions duty and ritual status wealth, power, mobility and exclusion prescriptive texts Buddhist/Jaina texts + archaeology

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- BRAHMANICAL NORM LIVED SOCIAL FIELD fourfold ranked varna occupations, jatis, clans and regions duty
- and ritual status wealth, power, mobility and exclusion prescriptive texts Buddhist/Jaina texts + archaeology

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Varna organised claims to hierarchy; it did not fully describe every social relation.
- Neither timeless rigidity nor unrestricted mobility is evidence-safe.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- BRAHMANICAL NORM LIVED SOCIAL FIELD fourfold ranked varna occupations, jatis, clans and regions duty
- and ritual status wealth, power, mobility and exclusion prescriptive texts Buddhist/Jaina texts + archaeology

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Neither timeless rigidity nor unrestricted mobility is evidence-safe.

06

STAGE 06

HOUSEHOLDERS, MERCHANTS, LABOUR AND DEPENDENCY

HOUSEHOLDERS, MERCHANTS, LABOUR AND DEPENDENCY | SUBSTANTIAL HOUSEHOLD HEAD | AGRARIAN AND SOCIAL AUTHORITY | WEALTHY MERCHANT-FINANCIER IN URBAN-COMMERCIAL NETWORKS | CULTIVATOR; CATEGORY CONTAINED UNEQUAL HOLDINGS AND DEPENDENCE | SPECIALISED PRODUCTION AND GUILD-LIKE ASSOCIATION | DEPENDENT AND UNFREE LABOUR CATEGORIES | OUTSIDE HOUSEHOLD IDEAL YET DEPENDENT ON LAY PATRONAGE

GAHAPATI: substantial household head / agrarian and social authority

SETTHI: wealthy merchant-financier in urban-commercial networks

KASSAKA: cultivator; category contained unequal holdings and dependence

KAMMIKAS / ARTISANS: specialised production and guild-like association

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- GAHAPATI: substantial household head / agrarian and social authority
- SETTHI: wealthy merchant-financier in urban-commercial networks
- KASSAKA: cultivator; category contained unequal holdings and dependence

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- KAMMIKAS / ARTISANS: specialised production and guild-like association
- DASA-KAMMAKARA: dependent and unfree labour categories
- RENUNCIANTS: outside household ideal yet dependent on lay patronage

DEBATE / LEGACY

- Wealth could raise influence without automatically cancelling ritual hierarchy.
- Use social terms with source and context; do not make them modern classes.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Use social terms with source and context; do not make them modern classes.

07

STAGE 07

WOMEN, HOUSEHOLD POWER AND EXCLUSION

WOMEN, HOUSEHOLD POWER AND EXCLUSION | TEXTUAL NORMS | PATRILINY, MARRIAGE CONTROL AND GENDERED DUTIES | BUDDHIST/JAINA MATERIAL | NUNS, DONORS, HOUSEHOLDERS AND DEBATES OVER ADMISSION | MATERIAL SILENCE | ARCHAEOLOGY RARELY IDENTIFIES GENDER WITHOUT CONTEXT | AGENCY EXISTED WITHIN UNEQUAL INSTITUTIONS; ELITE WOMEN CANNOT STAND

SOURCE / MATERIAL

- TEXTUAL NORMS: patriliny, marriage control and gendered duties
- BUDDHIST/JAINA MATERIAL: nuns, donors, householders and debates over admission

METHOD / DEBATE

- MATERIAL SILENCE: archaeology rarely identifies gender without context
- Agency existed within unequal institutions; elite women cannot stand for all women.

HISTORICAL RESULT

- Renunciation opened spaces but preserved hierarchy and dependence.
- VERDICT: recover variation without inventing equality or total seclusion.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: recover variation without inventing equality or total seclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: recover variation without inventing equality or total seclusion.

08

STAGE 08

SHRAMANA CHALLENGE AND SOCIAL RESPONSE

SHRAMANA CHALLENGE AND SOCIAL RESPONSE | RITUAL COST + URBAN CHANGE + SOCIAL MOBILITY + | BUDDHIST, JAINA, AJIVIKA AND OTHER RENUNCIANT CRITIQUES ETHICS, KARMA | SHRAMANA MOVEMENTS CHALLENGED HIERARCHY UNEVENLY, NOT ALL SOCIAL RANKING.

RITUAL COST + URBAN CHANGE + SOCIAL MOBILITY + SUFFERING

Buddhist, Jaina, Ajivika and other renunciant critiques ethics, karma, rebirth, non-injury, discipline and

new communities merchant and ruler patronage + monastic institutions + doctrinal competition

LIMIT: shramana movements challenged hierarchy unevenly, not all social ranking.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- RITUAL COST + URBAN CHANGE + SOCIAL MOBILITY + SUFFERING
- Buddhist, Jaina, Ajivika and other renunciant critiques ethics, karma, rebirth, non-injury, discipline and

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- new communities merchant and ruler patronage + monastic institutions + doctrinal competition
- LIMIT: shramana movements challenged hierarchy unevenly, not all social ranking.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- RITUAL COST + URBAN CHANGE + SOCIAL MOBILITY + SUFFERING
- Buddhist, Jaina, Ajivika and other renunciant critiques ethics, karma, rebirth, non-injury, discipline and

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT: shramana movements challenged hierarchy unevenly, not all social ranking.

09

STAGE 09

MATERIAL EVIDENCE: POTTERY, COINS, TOWNS AND ROUTES

MATERIAL EVIDENCE | POTTERY, COINS, TOWNS AND ROUTES | CONSUMPTION AND EARLY-HISTORIC SETTLEMENT HORIZON | DEFENCE, LABOUR MOBILISATION AND POLITICAL INVESTMENT | PUNCH-MARKED COINS | MONETISED EXCHANGE IN SELECTED CIRCUITS | CRAFT AREAS | SPECIALISED PRODUCTION AND URBAN DEMAND

SOURCE / MATERIAL	METHOD / DEBATE	HISTORICAL RESULT
NBPW → consumption and early-historic settlement horizon	CRAFT AREAS → specialised production and urban demand	No single marker proves a city, ruler, varna or religious community.
FORTIFICATIONS → defence, labour mobilisation and political investment	SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY → links villages, towns and political centres	Use convergence among artefact, layer, text and regional sequence.
PUNCH-MARKED COINS → monetised exchange in selected circuits	RIVERS/ROADS → movement of goods, armies, pilgrims and information	

SOURCE / MATERIAL

- NBPW → consumption and early-historic settlement horizon
- FORTIFICATIONS → defence, labour mobilisation and political investment
- PUNCH-MARKED COINS → monetised exchange in selected circuits

METHOD / DEBATE

- CRAFT AREAS → specialised production and urban demand
- SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY → links villages, towns and political centres
- RIVERS/ROADS → movement of goods, armies, pilgrims and information

HISTORICAL RESULT

- No single marker proves a city, ruler, varna or religious community.
- Use convergence among artefact, layer, text and regional sequence.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Use convergence among artefact, layer, text and regional sequence.

10

STAGE 10

CHANGE AND CONTINUITY ACROSS POLITY AND SOCIETY

CHANGE AND CONTINUITY ACROSS POLITY AND SOCIETY | LARGER STATES | COIN USE | RENUNCIANT INSTITUTIONS | AGRARIAN HOUSEHOLD | RITUAL HIERARCHY | LOCAL COMMUNITIES | MONARCHY VS GANA

CONTINUITY: kinship	agrarian household	ritual hierarchy	local communities
TENSION: monarchy vs gana	wealth vs status	norm vs practice	

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- CHANGE: larger states
- coin use
- renunciant institutions
- CONTINUITY: kinship
- agrarian household

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- ritual hierarchy
- local communities
- TENSION: monarchy vs gana
- wealth vs status
- norm vs practice

DEBATE / LEGACY

- REGIONALITY: Ganga plains != north-west != Deccan trajectories
- The Buddha age was accelerated restructuring, not a total social revolution.
- Best answers connect political capacity, economy, hierarchy and ethical critique.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Best answers connect political capacity, economy, hierarchy and ethical critique.

11

STAGE 11

EXAMINER-READY BUDDHA-AGE ANSWER SPINE

EXAMINER-READY BUDDHA-AGE ANSWER SPINE | DEFINE THE SIXTH-FIFTH CENTURY BCE CORE WITHIN A WIDER | BODY 1 | SOURCE HIERARCHY AND CHRONOLOGY CAUTION | BODY 2 | TERRITORIAL STATES, INSTITUTIONS AND AGRARIAN EXTRACTION | BODY 3 | TOWNS, TRADE, HOUSEHOLDERS, ARTISANS AND LABOUR

INTRO: define the sixth-fifth century BCE core within a wider early-historic range.

BODY 1: source hierarchy and chronology caution

BODY 2: territorial states, institutions and agrarian extraction

BODY 3: towns, trade, householders, artisans and labour

BODY 4: varna norm, lived hierarchy, gender and shramana critique

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- INTRO: define the sixth-fifth century BCE core within a wider early-historic range.
- BODY 1: source hierarchy and chronology caution
- BODY 2: territorial states, institutions and agrarian extraction

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- BODY 3: towns, trade, householders, artisans and labour
- BODY 4: varna norm, lived hierarchy, gender and shramana critique
- COUNTER: regional variation, composite texts and material-evidence limits

DEBATE / LEGACY

- CONCLUSION: state, economy and society changed together but unevenly.
- WRITE: process → named evidence → social effect → qualification.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: process → named evidence → social effect → qualification.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT | 1. SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA | 2. KEY CLASSIFICATION | 3. STUDY LINKS | 4. MUST-KNOW FACTS (PRELIMS) | 5. UPSC TRAPS | 6. CURRENT LINK | 7. MAINS ANGLES

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

- Mini-timeline
- 1. Snapshot & core idea
- 2. Key classification / data
- 3. Study links

ADVANCED DEBATE

- 4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)
- 5. UPSC Traps
- 6. Current link
- 7. Mains angles

LEGACY / NUANCE

- The political map contained monarchical states (rajyas), oligarchic states (ganas/sanghas), and tribal principalities
- The 16 great states were not identical; they differed in size, constitution, economy and military capacity.
- The period saw land and agrarian expansion, early historic cities, crafts, guilds, money and new social elites.
- Renunciant traditions emerged in a society where householders, traders, setthis and gahapatis became increasingly visible.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels